

Kaushik Basu, professor of economics at Cornell University and a member of the committee, wrote a strong dissenting note calling for, among other things, greater privatisation and permitting for-profit institutions in higher education. According to Basu: "A common presumption is that, if someone is interested in profit, that person will not be interested in providing good education. This is a fallacy. It is like assuming that, if Tata Motors is interested in making profit, it will not be interested in producing a good small car. However, in reality, its interest in pro-

ducing a good small car could be because it is interested in making profits. Likewise, in education, if a profit-making company wants to start a university, there is no reason why we should not allow this."

There is also a major imperative for privatisation. The Eleventh Plan envisages that by 2012 at least 15 per cent of those passing out from schools should enter college compared to only 11 per cent now. That would mean setting up around 1,500 universities across the country to meet the demand in the next five years—almost five times the existing number. That sort of huge infusion of funds can come only from the private sector. As Basu pointed out: "We have to recognise that it is not possible for any government, let alone the government of a developing nation, to run even the existing 300 universities with equal generosity. Such an agendum is bound to cause either a fiscal breakdown or doom the university system to mediocrity." What the Government can do is lay down norms and standards and ensure that private institutions follow them.

Make it Industry-linked

Experts say the era of producing vanilla graduates has to be quickly brought to an end. The buzzword is industry-linked education or job-related courses. The term vocational education is increasingly finding disfavour among decision makers because of the stigma

**THE UGC HQ
IN DELHI**



The Bureaucratic Maze

Organisations regulating higher education:

- University Grants Commission: Funding and recognition of institutions and degrees
- All India Council for Technical Education: Approval of technical institutions
- Medical Council of India: Recognition of Medical institutions
- Council of Architects: For recognising institutions of education in architecture
- National Council for Teacher Education: Recognition of teacher education institutions
- Bar Council of India: Recognition of law colleges
- Pharmacy Council of India: Approval of pharmacy institutions

attached to it that it is a "loser's choice". Pawan Agarwal, an IAS officer who has extensively researched the Indian higher education sector, says it is time to dispense with highfalutin notions that the main aim of Indian university system is to ennoble citizens. He points out that elsewhere in the world the debate has shifted to developing skills and abilities to innovate through education. Governments have also stopped referring to it just as

department of education. The UK Government now calls it the Department of Education and Skills. Australia calls it the Department of Education, Employment and Workplace Relations. The key is to make degree courses more linked to industry and its needs. Skill development is now considered key to good education—what management expert C.K. Prahalad terms as the equivalent of having an Intel inside.

The British have aban-

EXPERTSPEAK

"Full autonomy is the key. A university must be allowed to decide policy on faculty and admissions of students."

NARAYANA MURTHY
Chairman, Infosys



"Vocational stream is looked upon as a loser's choice. We need to create pathways to pursue higher studies."

PAWAN AGARWAL
Education expert and author



THE ERA OF PRODUCING VANILLA GRADUATES IS OVER.
Degree courses have to be more linked to industry and its needs.

